

What are website design trends and styles that have been popular? Please make a list of website design trends and styles that have been popular since the creation of the internet. For each trend or style please provide a detailed description of the elements of that design and the common names used to refer to that style.

## Major Website Design Trends and Styles, 1991–Present

Web-design movements rarely begin or end cleanly. Most overlap, reappear as nostalgia, or survive within particular sectors. The dates below therefore indicate each style's **main period of popularity**, not strict boundaries.

The first public websites were primarily static, text-oriented documents. Over more than three decades, the medium expanded toward multimedia-rich pages, applications, immersive storytelling, and adaptive interfaces.  Web Design Mu... +1

### 1. Text-Only or Document-Style Web

**Popular:** 1991–1995

**Common names:** Early Web, text-first design, document web, academic web, CERN style, raw HTML

The earliest websites looked more like technical papers or directories than designed publications.

### Typical elements

- Plain text on a white or gray browser background
- Blue underlined hyperlinks and purple visited links
- One continuous vertical column
- Browser-default serif typefaces, usually Times
- Headings, paragraphs, numbered lists, and horizontal rules
- Almost no images, ornamentation, or custom layout
- Navigation embedded directly in the document
- Content hierarchy determined by HTML rather than graphic composition

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The aesthetic was largely a consequence of early HTML's purpose: describing and linking documents rather than precisely arranging visual interfaces.

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## 2. Personal Homepage Vernacular

**Popular:** 1994–2002

**Common names:** Personal homepage style, GeoCities aesthetic, amateur web, vernacular web, Web 1.0 aesthetic

As ordinary users began publishing websites, homepages became highly personal digital rooms.

## Typical elements

- “Welcome to my homepage” headings
- Visitor counters
- Guestbooks
- “Under construction” graphics
- Personal biographies, hobby pages, link collections, and fan shrines
- Bright or patterned backgrounds
- Animated GIFs and clip art
- Web rings and reciprocal-link badges
- Email links and “sign my guestbook” prompts
- Inconsistent type sizes and colors
- Informal navigation assembled page by page

This style is now frequently revived under labels such as **webcore**, **old-web revival**, and **GeoCities nostalgia**.

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## 3. Cyber, Techno, and Y2K Futurism

**Popular:** 1995–2003; revived in the 2020s

**Common names:** Cyber aesthetic, techno style, Y2K web design, cybercore, digital futurism, millennium futurism

Early commercial culture often represented the internet as a futuristic electronic frontier.

## Typical elements

- Black, dark blue, or metallic backgrounds
- Neon cyan, electric blue, lime green, violet, and silver
- Glowing lines and lens flares
- Circuit-board patterns, grids, wires, and data motifs
- Chrome or metallic typography
- Abstract 3D forms
- Rotating globes and network diagrams
- Pixelated or techno typefaces
- Terms such as “cyberspace,” “portal,” “virtual,” and “digital”
- Interfaces inspired by science-fiction control panels

The look combined optimism about technology with imagery borrowed from cyberpunk, video games, and electronic music.

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## 4. Browser-Default Brutalism

**Popular:** 1991–1998; revived after approximately 2014

**Common names:** Raw HTML, primitive web, default web, unstyled web, HTML brutality

Some early sites were “brutalist” by necessity rather than conscious artistic intent. Later designers deliberately revived the look.

### Typical elements

- Default browser fonts and link colors
- Minimal or absent CSS

- Exposed lists, tables, buttons, and form controls
- Little concern for visual polish
- Abrupt hierarchy and dense content
- Visible technical structure
- Few decorative images
- Fast loading and direct navigation
- Deliberately awkward or anti-commercial composition in later revivals

Contemporary brutalist sites often use rawness as a statement against polished, homogeneous corporate design.

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## 5. Table-Based Layout

**Popular:** 1996–2005

**Common names:** Table layout, sliced-table design, spacer-GIF layout, fixed-table design

Before CSS layout became reliable, designers used HTML tables—originally intended for data—to position page elements.

### Typical elements

- Nested tables creating headers, sidebars, and columns
- Fixed widths, commonly optimized for 640×480 or 800×600 screens
- Transparent spacer GIFs controlling gaps
- Image slices reconstructed inside table cells
- Precisely aligned navigation bars

- Small text packed into constrained columns
- Layouts that broke when text size or browser conditions changed
- “Best viewed in...” notices

Table layout enabled far more visual control than early document-style HTML, but produced rigid, inaccessible markup.

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## 6. Portal and Directory Design

**Popular:** 1996–2005

**Common names:** Web portal, directory portal, dashboard homepage, information portal

Major services sought to become the user’s starting point for the entire web.

### Typical elements

- Dense multi-column layouts
- Search box near the top
- News, weather, finance, sports, email, and shopping modules
- Extensive category directories
- Small typography and many hyperlinks
- Personalized homepage widgets
- Banner advertising
- Tabs and boxed content sections
- High information density above the fold

Yahoo!, MSN, AOL, and similar services helped establish the portal as a dominant commercial-web format.

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## 7. Banner-and-Button Web

**Popular:** 1995–2003

**Common names:** Banner-heavy design, button web, badge web, 88×31 aesthetic

Small graphic assets became a basic visual vocabulary of the early web.

### Typical elements

- Rectangular banner advertisements
- Compact 88×31 affiliation or technology badges
- Graphical navigation buttons
- “Made with...” and browser-compatibility badges
- Award icons
- Download buttons
- Repeated animated promotional graphics
- Beveled edges and high-contrast text

Buttons often communicated identity, software allegiance, community membership, or technical capability as much as navigation.

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## 8. Frame-Based Design

**Popular:** 1996–2002

**Common names:** Frameset design, framed site, persistent navigation frame

HTML frames allowed multiple documents to appear in separate regions of one browser window.

### Typical elements

- Navigation permanently fixed in a left or top frame
- Main content loading into a separate pane
- Visible frame borders or scrollbars
- Independent scrolling regions
- Compact tree-style menus
- Difficulty bookmarking individual content pages
- Inconsistent behavior on smaller screens

Frames solved the problem of persistent navigation but introduced usability, accessibility, and search-indexing problems.

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## 9. Pixel Art and Low-Resolution Graphics

**Popular:** 1995–2005; recurring thereafter

**Common names:** Pixel aesthetic, 8-bit design, low-res web, bitmap style, pixelcore

Limited bandwidth, small screens, and early graphic formats encouraged compact bitmap artwork.



## Typical elements

- Hard-edged icons
- Pixel fonts
- Tiny illustrations
- Restricted color palettes
- Dithered gradients
- Repeating tiled textures
- Video-game references
- GIF-based animation
- Intentionally visible pixels

Modern versions often use pixelation deliberately to evoke early computing, games, or internet nostalgia.

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## 10. Grunge Web Design

**Popular:** 1997–2008

**Common names:** Grunge, distressed design, dirty design, underground style

Influenced by alternative music, skate culture, zines, and experimental print graphics, grunge rejected clean digital surfaces.

## Typical elements

- Torn paper and tape

- Scratches, stains, photocopy noise, and ink splatters
- Uneven baselines
- Handwritten or distressed fonts
- Layered collage
- Muted earth tones or aggressive red-and-black palettes
- Asymmetrical navigation
- Rough-edged image masks
- Deliberate visual disorder

It was common on music, fashion, youth-culture, and portfolio sites.

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## 11. Flash Intro and Splash-Screen Design

**Popular:** 1997–2007

**Common names:** Flash intro, splash page, cinematic intro, skip-intro era

Many websites opened with an animated presentation before allowing access to the main content.

### Typical elements

- Full-screen logo animations
- Loading bars and percentage indicators
- Sound effects or music
- “Enter site” buttons
- “Skip intro” links

- Motion typography
- Animated transitions
- Minimal searchable text
- Dependence on the Adobe Flash plug-in

Splash pages treated a website as a branded presentation rather than a directly accessible information system.

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## 12. Experimental Flash and Immersive Multimedia

**Popular:** 1998–2010

**Common names:** Flash site, immersive web, interactive multimedia, experiential web, motion web

Flash became a platform for interfaces that behaved more like games, films, or interactive art installations.

### Typical elements

- Full-screen vector animation
- Custom cursors
- Sound-responsive interaction
- Nonlinear navigation
- Zooming or spatial interfaces
- Animated menus
- Interactive characters and environments

- Transitions between every section
- Little resemblance to standard webpages
- Portfolio and entertainment experiences built as single applications

The style produced influential digital art and advertising, although it often sacrificed accessibility, performance, and conventional navigation.

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## 13. Corporate Blue and Early E-Commerce

**Popular:** 1998–2007

**Common names:** Corporate web, enterprise design, dot-com corporate, institutional web

Companies adopted a conservative visual language intended to signal reliability and technical competence.

### Typical elements

- Blue, gray, white, and muted accent colors
- Horizontal navigation bars
- Left-hand navigation columns
- Stock photography of offices and professionals
- Small Arial or Verdana text
- Boxed page sections
- "About us," "solutions," "investors," and "contact" menus
- Fixed 760–960-pixel layouts
- Dense footers and utility links

- Product or service diagrams

This style remained especially common in banking, software, telecommunications, and professional services.

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## 14. Liquid or Fluid Layout

**Popular:** 1998–2012

**Common names:** Fluid design, liquid layout, percentage-based layout, elastic layout

Fluid pages expanded and contracted with the browser window instead of remaining at a fixed width.

### Typical elements

- Columns sized with percentages
- Text lines changing length with the window
- Sidebars stretching or compressing
- Large use of available screen space
- Minimum- and maximum-width constraints in later implementations
- Occasional extremely long lines on large monitors
- Images that did not always scale with the layout

Fluid design anticipated responsive thinking, although it lacked the controlled breakpoints later provided by media queries.

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## 15. CSS and Web-Standards Minimalism

**Popular:** 2001–2008

**Common names:** Standards-based design, CSS design, semantic web design, CSS Zen style

Designers began separating structure from presentation and replacing table-heavy markup with CSS.

### Typical elements

- Semantic headings, lists, and content sections
- CSS-controlled typography, spacing, and backgrounds
- Cleaner source code
- Reusable style sheets
- Greater consistency between pages
- Rounded or rectangular content panels
- Two- and three-column layouts using floats
- Greater attention to accessibility
- Often restrained, typography-led visual design

This was as much an engineering and accessibility movement as a visual trend.

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## 16. Blog and Chronological Feed Design

**Popular:** 1999–present; especially dominant 2003–2012

**Common names:** Blog layout, weblog style, reverse-chronological feed, journal design

Publishing platforms standardized a recognizable content format.

### Typical elements

- Posts displayed newest first
- Date and author metadata
- Comments below articles
- Categories, tags, and archives
- Blogrolls
- RSS subscription icons
- Narrow central reading column
- Sidebar containing search, recent posts, and links
- Pagination or “older posts” navigation
- Highly visible post titles

This structure later influenced social-media feeds, news sites, and content-marketing platforms.

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## 17. Web 2.0 Gloss

**Popular:** 2004–2010

**Common names:** Web 2.0 style, glossy web, shiny-button design, Ajax-era design

The growth of interactive web applications brought a cheerful, polished visual language.

### Typical elements

- Glossy buttons
- Strong gradients
- Reflections and highlights
- Rounded corners
- Large friendly logos
- Bright lime, orange, cyan, and blue accents
- Oversized sans-serif headings
- Starbursts and “beta” badges
- Soft drop shadows
- Large call-to-action buttons
- White backgrounds with generous spacing
- Ajax interactions that updated content without reloading the page

The aesthetic suggested that software could be approachable, social, and easy to use.

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## 18. Reflective Floors and Aqua Interfaces

**Popular:** 2001–2009

**Common names:** Aqua style, glassy UI, reflective design, Apple-inspired gloss

Influenced heavily by early-2000s operating-system interfaces, designers simulated polished glass and translucent plastic.

### Typical elements

- Gel-like buttons



- High-gloss highlights
- Mirrored logos and images
- Blue glass textures
- Translucent panels
- Rounded capsules
- Metallic borders
- Water droplets and light flares
- Deep shadows beneath floating objects

This overlaps with Web 2.0 gloss but is more specifically associated with glass, liquid, and polished-plastic surfaces.

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## 19. Letterpress, Texture, and Handmade Design

**Popular:** 2006–2013

**Common names:** Textured web design, letterpress style, handcrafted web, tactile design

As CSS and image techniques improved, designers tried to make digital pages feel materially crafted.

### Typical elements

- Paper, linen, wood, leather, or fabric textures
- Letterpress-style inset typography
- Stitched borders
- Ribbons and folded corners

- Hand-drawn illustrations
- Ornamental dividers
- Vintage labels
- Subtle noise overlays
- Warm, muted colors
- Physical metaphors such as notebooks and bulletin boards

This style was particularly common in portfolios, cafés, craft brands, and boutique retail.

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## 20. Skeuomorphism

**Popular:** 2007–2013

**Common names:** Skeuomorphic design, realistic UI, rich interface design, real-world metaphor design

Skeuomorphism makes digital objects resemble familiar physical materials or devices. It was intended to make unfamiliar interactions understandable through recognizable visual metaphors. NN/g Nielsen Norman...

### Typical elements

- Realistic leather, metal, paper, wood, and fabric
- Buttons resembling physical switches
- Notebooks with page edges and binding
- Shelves for digital books or media
- Deep shadows, bevels, reflections, and highlights

- Simulated knobs, dials, and controls
- Highly rendered icons
- Physical metaphors for files, calendars, trash, and tools
- Rich visual feedback when controls are pressed

The style was prominent in early smartphone interfaces and influenced web applications during the same period.

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## 21. Magazine and Editorial Grid Design

**Popular:** 2007–present

**Common names:** Editorial web design, magazine layout, news grid, content grid

Publishers borrowed heavily from print editorial design.

### Typical elements

- Strong typographic hierarchy
- Multiple content columns
- Hero stories paired with secondary items
- Modular image-and-headline blocks
- Section labels and issue-style organization
- Pull quotes and captions
- Serif display typography
- Grid-based alignment
- Carefully art-directed photography

- Dense but structured front pages

Later versions became more spacious and responsive, but the editorial-grid logic remains widespread.

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## 22. Fixed-Width 960-Grid Design

**Popular:** 2007–2013

**Common names:** 960 grid, fixed-grid layout, centered desktop layout

The 960-pixel-wide grid became a common framework for designing predictable desktop pages.

### Typical elements

- Centered white or light content canvas
- 12- or 16-column grid
- Fixed-width header and footer
- Consistent gutters
- Clearly aligned cards and columns
- Large empty margins on widescreen displays
- Desktop-first composition
- Predictable ad and sidebar dimensions

The approach brought discipline to layout but became less suitable as smartphone traffic increased.

## 23. Single-Page Portfolio Design

**Popular:** 2008–present

**Common names:** One-page website, single-page site, scrolling portfolio, long-page design

Small businesses and creative professionals increasingly placed an entire website on one vertically scrolling page.

### Typical elements

- Anchor-link navigation
- Sequential sections for introduction, work, services, and contact
- Large hero area
- Smooth scrolling
- Full-width bands of contrasting color
- Portfolio thumbnails
- Concise copy
- Strong calls to action
- Minimal secondary navigation

This style later merged with landing-page design and scroll-based storytelling.

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## 24. Minimalism

**Popular:** 2008–present

**Common names:** Minimal web design, clean design, reductionism, Swiss-inspired web design

Minimalism removes nonessential decoration and emphasizes hierarchy, spacing, and content.

### Typical elements

- Restricted color palette
- Generous negative space
- Small number of typefaces
- Clean geometric alignment
- Limited navigation
- Few visible borders
- Large photographs or restrained illustrations
- Concise language
- Strong hierarchy created through size and spacing
- Emphasis on one primary action

Minimalism is broader than flat design: a minimalist page can still use texture, depth, or realistic imagery.

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## 25. Responsive Web Design

**Popular:** 2010–present

**Common names:** Responsive design, RWD, adaptive fluid design, device-agnostic design

Ethan Marcotte named and formalized responsive web design in 2010. Its foundational techniques were flexible grids, flexible images, and CSS media queries.  A List Apart +2

### Typical elements

- Layouts that reflow at defined breakpoints
- Flexible images and media
- Columns stacking on small screens
- Navigation transforming for mobile
- Type and spacing adjusted by viewport size
- Touch-friendly controls
- Content prioritization
- One codebase serving multiple device classes

Responsive design is primarily an architectural method rather than an aesthetic, but it profoundly changed the appearance and organization of websites.

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## 26. Mobile-First Design

**Popular:** 2011–present

**Common names:** Mobile first, small-screen-first design, progressive enhancement

Rather than shrinking a desktop design, mobile-first practice begins with the smallest useful interface and progressively adds complexity.

### Typical elements

- Single-column base layout
- Essential content shown first
- Large touch targets
- Short forms
- Compact navigation
- Reduced image weight
- Progressive enhancement for wider screens
- Performance-conscious assets
- Simplified interaction patterns
- Avoidance of hover-dependent controls

It encouraged designers to treat content priority and performance as core design concerns.

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## 27. Flat Design

**Popular:** 2012–2017; still highly influential

**Common names:** Flat UI, flat design, two-dimensional design, metro style

Flat design removed much of skeuomorphism's texture and simulated depth. It became broadly popular around 2012. NNG Nielsen Norman...



## Typical elements

- Solid color fields
- Simple geometric icons
- Minimal gradients and shadows
- Sans-serif typography
- Rectangular or borderless buttons
- Bright accent palettes
- Large areas of negative space
- Emphasis on content over ornament
- Simplified pictograms
- Grid-based composition

Overly flat interfaces sometimes made clickable elements difficult to recognize because controls lacked clear visual signifiers. NNG Nielsen Norman...

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## 28. Metro or Tile-Based Design

**Popular:** 2010–2015

**Common names:** Metro design, tile UI, modern UI, live-tile design

Associated with Microsoft's interface systems, Metro emphasized typography, flat color, and rectangular modules.

## Typical elements

- Large colored tiles
- Asymmetrical modular grids
- Bold sans-serif headings
- Minimal iconography
- Content displayed directly inside navigation elements
- Horizontal or panoramic movement
- Strong information hierarchy
- Little surface decoration
- Motion used to communicate structure

Metro was one of the major influences on the broader flat-design movement.

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## 29. Card-Based Design

**Popular:** 2012–present

**Common names:** Card UI, modular design, tile design, content cards, container-based design

Cards package related information into reusable, rearrangeable units.

### Typical elements

- Rectangular content containers
- Image, heading, metadata, and action grouped together
- Repeated modules in grids or feeds
- Rounded corners or subtle borders

- Responsive reordering
- Consistent internal padding
- Independent cards that can be filtered or sorted
- Suitable structures for articles, products, profiles, and dashboards

Cards became particularly useful for responsive interfaces because each unit can move independently as screen width changes.

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## 30. Parallax Scrolling

**Popular:** 2011–2016; recurring thereafter

**Common names:** Parallax design, layered scrolling, depth scrolling

Parallax creates an illusion of depth by moving foreground and background layers at different speeds.

### Typical elements

- Large background images
- Layered illustrations
- Elements entering or leaving during scroll
- Fixed background sections
- Cinematic transitions
- Long vertical narratives
- Scroll-triggered animation
- Product or campaign storytelling

- Strong sense of depth

Heavy implementations could create performance, motion-sensitivity, and usability problems.

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## 31. Full-Screen Photography

**Popular:** 2011–present

**Common names:** Full-bleed design, hero-image design, photographic web design, immersive photography

Faster connections and larger displays enabled imagery to dominate the opening viewport.

### Typical elements

- Edge-to-edge hero photographs
- Minimal text over imagery
- Transparent or overlaid navigation
- Full-screen slideshows
- Large editorial typography
- Dark overlays to preserve readability
- Strong art direction
- Reduced visible interface chrome
- Emotional or aspirational branding

Travel, hospitality, architecture, fashion, and luxury brands adopted this approach extensively.

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## 32. Video Background Design

**Popular:** 2013–present

**Common names:** Background video, cinematic homepage, motion hero, video-first design

Short looping video replaced static hero images on many promotional sites.

### Typical elements

- Muted autoplay video
- Full-viewport hero section
- Concise overlaid headline
- Slow-motion lifestyle or product footage
- Dark or colored readability overlay
- Poster image fallback
- Minimal controls
- Seamless looping
- Strong cinematic art direction

Effective implementations compress footage carefully and provide alternatives for reduced-motion and limited-bandwidth users.

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## 33. Hamburger and Off-Canvas Navigation

**Popular:** 2012–present

**Common names:** Hamburger menu, drawer navigation, off-canvas menu, hidden navigation

Mobile constraints led designers to conceal navigation behind a compact icon.

### Typical elements

- Three-line menu icon
- Navigation sliding from the side
- Full-screen menu overlays
- Reduced header clutter
- Hierarchical accordion menus
- Touch-oriented spacing
- Dimmed background behind the drawer

Although visually economical, hidden navigation can reduce discoverability when used unnecessarily on wide screens.

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## 34. Flat 2.0 or Semi-Flat Design

**Popular:** 2015–present

**Common names:** Flat 2.0, semi-flat, almost flat, dimensional flat design

Flat 2.0 retained flat design's simplicity while reintroducing restrained depth to clarify interaction. Nielsen Norman Group describes it as a usability-oriented alternative to excessively flat interfaces. NN/G Nielsen Norman...

### Typical elements

- Subtle drop shadows
- Light gradients
- Distinct button backgrounds
- Layered cards
- Clear hover and focus states
- Simple iconography
- Strong contrast between interactive and static elements
- Minimal but meaningful depth

Most contemporary “flat” websites are actually closer to this moderated form.

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## 35. Material Design

**Popular:** 2014–present

**Common names:** Material Design, material UI, paper-and-ink interface

Google's Material Design system combined flat visual language with spatial rules, motion, and layered surfaces.

### Typical elements

- Cards and sheets existing on conceptual planes
- Controlled elevation and shadows
- Floating action buttons
- Bold color palettes
- Consistent spacing systems
- Grid-based layouts
- Responsive components
- Motion that explains transitions
- Standardized icons
- Clear interaction states

It became especially influential in application interfaces, dashboards, and component libraries.

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## 36. Geometric and Abstract Minimalism

**Popular:** 2015–present

**Common names:** Geometric web design, abstract minimalism, shape-based design

Designers supplemented minimal layouts with simple abstract forms.

### Typical elements

- Circles, triangles, lines, blobs, and polygons
- Overlapping translucent shapes
- Flat or gently graded colors



- Cropped geometric photography
- Diagonal section dividers
- Grid-aligned typography
- Decorative line work
- Modular composition

This approach gives otherwise restrained pages a recognizable visual identity without relying on detailed illustration.

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## 37. Duotone and Color-Overlay Design

**Popular:** 2015–2019; recurring thereafter

**Common names:** Duotone, color wash, gradient map, bichromatic design

Photographs were recolored using two contrasting hues or covered by strong translucent color fields.

### Typical elements

- Two-color photographic treatment
- High-contrast imagery
- Bright brand colors
- Monochromatic page sections
- Bold sans-serif type
- Color overlays improving text legibility
- Strong consistency across varied source images

Duotone treatments made ordinary stock images feel more cohesive and brand-specific.

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## 38. Gradient Revival

**Popular:** 2016–present

**Common names:** Modern gradients, gradient revival, color-transition design, aurora gradients

After flat design temporarily suppressed gradients, designers returned to them in a softer and more expressive form.

### Typical elements

- Multi-hue backgrounds
- Vibrant blue-purple-pink transitions
- Mesh gradients
- Gradient text
- Blurred color fields
- Animated gradients
- Subtle atmospheric transitions
- Gradient borders and buttons

Unlike glossy Web 2.0 gradients, modern gradients usually create atmosphere rather than simulate a shiny physical surface.

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## 39. Bold Typography and Type-First Design

**Popular:** 2016–present

**Common names:** Typography-led design, type-first web, oversized type, editorial typography

Improved browser font support allowed typography to become a primary visual asset.

### Typical elements

- Extra-large headlines
- Variable or custom webfonts
- Dramatic scale contrast
- Text occupying most of the first viewport
- Kinetic or animated lettering
- Unusual line breaks
- Condensed, extended, or high-contrast display faces
- Minimal imagery
- Type integrated into the grid as a graphic shape

Some implementations intentionally crop words or let typography extend beyond the viewport.

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## 40. Split-Screen Layout

**Popular:** 2015–2020; still used selectively

**Common names:** Split screen, divided layout, dual-panel design, 50/50 layout

The viewport is divided into two contrasting but related regions.

### Typical elements

- Two equal vertical panels
- Image on one side and text on the other
- Two products, audiences, or choices presented simultaneously
- Contrasting colors or imagery
- Independent scrolling in some cases
- Strong central dividing line
- Balanced symmetrical composition
- Panels stacking vertically on mobile

It works particularly well when a site needs to present a clear binary choice.

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## 41. Asymmetrical and Broken-Grid Design

**Popular:** 2016–present

**Common names:** Broken grid, asymmetrical layout, deconstructed grid, editorial asymmetry

This style deliberately violates conventional column alignment while maintaining an underlying compositional system.

### Typical elements

- Overlapping text and images

- Elements crossing grid boundaries
- Uneven columns
- Off-center focal points
- Large empty regions
- Cropped content
- Layered typography
- Irregular but controlled spacing
- Strong editorial influence

The result feels more expressive and art-directed than a uniform card grid.

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## 42. Illustrative SaaS Design

**Popular:** 2016–present

**Common names:** SaaS illustration style, onboarding illustration, tech-brand illustration

Technology companies increasingly used custom illustration to explain abstract services and make brands appear approachable.

### Typical elements

- Friendly characters
- Metaphorical scenes representing workflows
- Simplified vector shapes
- Consistent brand palette
- Rounded geometry

- Illustrations beside product copy
- Step-by-step diagrams
- Decorative spot illustrations
- Lightweight animation

The style is especially common on software homepages, empty states, onboarding flows, and error pages.

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## 43. Corporate Memphis

**Popular:** 2017–2022; still influential

**Common names:** Corporate Memphis, Alegria style, big-tech illustration, flat people illustration

Corporate Memphis is a recognizable subset of corporate illustration.

### Typical elements

- Exaggerated human proportions
- Very large limbs and small heads
- Bright, non-natural skin colors
- Rounded organic forms
- Simplified facial features
- Flat fills with little shading
- Diverse groups engaged in collaborative activities
- Optimistic and nonthreatening tone

- Abstract plants and geometric scenery

Its widespread adoption eventually produced criticism that technology branding had become visually interchangeable.

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## 44. Motion UI and Microinteractions

**Popular:** 2015–present

**Common names:** Motion design, UI animation, microinteractions, interaction animation

Small animations communicate system status, causality, and feedback.

### Typical elements

- Buttons reacting to hover or tap
- Animated form validation
- Loading indicators
- Menu transitions
- Progress animations
- Pull-to-refresh effects
- Icons morphing between states
- Content smoothly entering or reorganizing
- Animated confirmation feedback
- Scroll-linked transitions

Unlike cinematic Flash sites, microinteractions generally support a focused functional purpose.

## 45. Scrollytelling

**Popular:** 2012–present

**Common names:** Scrollytelling, scroll-driven storytelling, interactive narrative, data story

Scrollytelling reveals narrative content as the reader moves through a page.

### Typical elements

- Sticky graphics beside changing text
- Maps or charts updating with scroll position
- Chapter-like sections
- Sequential animation
- Full-screen story panels
- Controlled pacing
- Progressive data annotation
- Integrated photography, audio, and video
- Long-form editorial structure

It is common in journalism, data visualization, institutional reports, and product launches.

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## 46. Dark-Mode Design

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** Dark mode, dark theme, night mode, inverted UI



Dark interfaces moved from specialist applications into mainstream websites and operating systems.

### Typical elements

- Near-black rather than pure-black backgrounds
- Light gray text
- Bright or luminous accents
- Reduced-intensity imagery
- Subtle borders instead of heavy shadows
- Theme toggle or system-preference detection
- Careful elevation through tonal contrast
- Adjusted illustrations and logos for dark surfaces

Dark mode is both a visual preference and an interface state; a well-designed version requires more than merely inverting colors.

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## 47. Neumorphism

**Popular:** 2019–2021; still used selectively

**Common names:** Neumorphism, soft UI, new skeuomorphism, soft skeuomorphism

Neumorphism combines flat design with softly extruded controls that appear formed from the background itself. It is part of the broader progression from skeuomorphism to flat design and back toward subtle tactility. nn/g Nielsen Norman...

## Typical elements

- Background and controls using nearly identical colors
- Paired light and dark shadows
- Softly raised or inset buttons
- Rounded corners
- Low-contrast pastel surfaces
- Minimal outlines
- Smooth, plastic-like forms
- Monochromatic palettes

Its low contrast can create accessibility and discoverability problems, particularly for controls and form states.

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## 48. Glassmorphism

**Popular:** 2020–present

**Common names:** Glassmorphism, frosted glass, translucent UI, acrylic design

Glassmorphism creates the appearance of translucent panels floating over colored or photographic backgrounds.

## Typical elements

- Background blur
- Semi-transparent white or tinted panels

- Thin translucent borders
- Soft shadows
- Saturated gradients behind the panels
- Layered depth
- Rounded rectangles
- Bright highlights
- Floating cards

The visual metaphor resembles frosted glass rather than the highly reflective “Aqua” surfaces of the early 2000s.

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## 49. Claymorphism and Soft 3D

**Popular:** 2021–present

**Common names:** Claymorphism, clay UI, soft 3D, plasticine design

Claymorphism uses rounded, toy-like 3D objects and controls.

### Typical elements

- Inflated shapes
- Soft, thick shadows
- Rounded corners
- Pastel palettes
- Matte surfaces
- Friendly 3D characters

- Simplified objects resembling clay or foam
- Isometric or front-facing compositions
- Playful depth without strict realism

It appears frequently in fintech, education, consumer applications, and friendly technology branding.

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## 50. 3D Web Design

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** Interactive 3D, WebGL design, real-time 3D web, spatial web design

Improved browser graphics enabled real-time three-dimensional scenes.

### Typical elements

- Rotatable product models
- 3D typography
- Particle systems
- Interactive environments
- Camera movement linked to scrolling
- Dynamic lighting
- Product configurators
- Virtual showrooms
- Spatial navigation
- Depth-responsive cursor interaction

This style ranges from useful product visualization to highly experimental digital experiences.

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## 51. Immersive Product Storytelling

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** Product storytelling, cinematic product page, launch experience, product theater

High-end product pages increasingly behave like directed visual narratives.

### Typical elements

- Sticky product renders
- Exploded or assembled product views
- Seamless section transitions
- Scroll-controlled camera movement
- Minimal copy revealed sequentially
- Full-viewport video
- Feature callouts synchronized with animation
- Controlled pacing
- Premium photography and sound
- Strong focus on one product

It combines scrollytelling, 3D, motion, and editorial art direction.

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## 52. Maximalism

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** Digital maximalism, visual overload, expressive web design, more-is-more design

Maximalism emerged partly as a reaction to restrained, highly standardized minimalism.

### Typical elements

- Dense composition
- Numerous colors and typefaces
- Pattern mixing
- Collage
- Large decorative elements
- Layered images and text
- Animated ornaments
- Competing focal points
- Highly individual visual language
- Deliberate excess

Strong maximalist design still uses hierarchy; it is not simply random clutter.

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## 53. Neo-Brutalism

**Popular:** 2019–present

**Common names:** Neo-brutalism, neubrutalism, colorful brutalism, pop brutalism

Neo-brutalism combines raw, confrontational composition with bright contemporary branding.

### Typical elements

- Thick black outlines
- Hard offset shadows
- Flat saturated colors
- Large block typography
- Rectangular buttons and cards
- Minimal gradients
- Visible borders around most components
- Intentionally blunt spacing
- Cartoon-like icons or illustrations
- High contrast and playful awkwardness

Compared with raw HTML brutalism, neo-brutalism is usually meticulously designed despite looking rough.

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## 54. Retro Web and Webcore Revival

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** Webcore, old-web revival, internet nostalgia, GeoCities revival, retro internet aesthetic

Designers intentionally recreate early-web imagery using modern technology.

## Typical elements

- Default-style blue links
- Browser windows used as design motifs
- Pixel icons and animated GIFs
- Tiled star or cloud backgrounds
- Visitor counters
- Marquee-like moving text
- ASCII art
- Low-resolution images
- Faux dialog boxes
- Bright, clashing colors
- Nostalgic references to dial-up culture

Unlike authentic 1990s sites, revivalist versions are often responsive, accessible, and technically sophisticated beneath the surface.

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## 55. Y2K Revival

**Popular:** 2020–present

**Common names:** Y2K revival, cyber Y2K, chrome futurism, millennium aesthetic

This revival revisits late-1990s and early-2000s ideas of the digital future.

## Typical elements



- Chrome typography
- Metallic gradients
- Bubble-like forms
- Translucent plastic
- Blue, pink, silver, and lime palettes
- Stars, flames, tribal motifs, and butterflies
- Low-resolution digital photography
- Futuristic techno fonts
- Lens flares and liquid shapes
- Interfaces inspired by old media players and operating systems

It differs from generic retro-web design by emphasizing millennium-era fashion and futurism.

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## 56. Organic Shapes and Blob Design

**Popular:** 2017–2022; still used

**Common names:** Blob design, organic web design, fluid shapes, amorphous design

Rigid rectangular grids were softened with irregular, rounded shapes.

### Typical elements

- Asymmetrical blobs
- Wavy section boundaries
- Organic image masks

- Hand-drawn curves
- Pastel or gradient fills
- Floating abstract forms
- Rounded type and controls
- Soft transitions between sections

The style communicates friendliness and informality, particularly in wellness, education, and consumer software.

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## 57. Bento Grid Design

**Popular:** 2022–present

**Common names:** Bento grid, bento-box layout, modular showcase grid, feature grid

Bento grids organize content into differently sized rectangular modules resembling a compartmentalized lunch box.

### Typical elements

- Large and small cards fitted into one grid
- Rounded corners
- One feature or concept per module
- Mixed media: charts, text, animation, screenshots, and icons
- Clear visual grouping
- Consistent gaps
- Dashboard-like density

- Responsive rearrangement
- Strong suitability for feature summaries

It is related to card design but creates a more unified, poster-like composition.

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## 58. Minimal SaaS and Landing-Page Homogeneity

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** SaaS minimalism, startup landing-page style, conversion design, template aesthetic

A standardized commercial language emerged through design systems, templates, and conversion optimization.

### Typical elements

- Short navigation bar
- Large benefit-oriented headline
- Product screenshot in the hero
- Gradient or abstract background
- Customer-logo strip
- Three- or four-column feature section
- Testimonial cards
- Pricing table
- Frequently asked questions
- Repeated call-to-action buttons

- Rounded cards and restrained shadows

It is efficient and familiar but often criticized for making unrelated companies look alike.

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## 59. Design-System and Component-Driven Aesthetics

**Popular:** 2016–present

**Common names:** Design-system design, component-based UI, atomic design, systemized interface

Reusable interface libraries have shaped not only implementation but visual style.

### Typical elements

- Standardized buttons, inputs, alerts, and cards
- Consistent spacing tokens
- Limited color roles
- Predictable typography scale
- Reusable page templates
- Uniform corner radii
- Documented interaction states
- Accessibility specifications
- Interfaces assembled from repeatable components

This approach improves consistency and scalability, although rigid systems can produce visual sameness.

## 60. Accessibility-Led and Inclusive Design

**Popular:** Increasingly prominent from the late 2010s onward

**Common names:** Accessible design, inclusive design, universal design, accessibility-first design

Accessibility is a practice rather than a decorative style, but it increasingly affects visible design conventions.

### Typical elements

- Strong text and control contrast
- Clearly visible keyboard focus
- Underlined or otherwise recognizable links
- Large touch targets
- Legible type sizes and line spacing
- Explicit form labels
- Error messages not conveyed by color alone
- Reduced-motion options
- Captions and transcripts
- Semantic hierarchy
- Simple, predictable navigation

Its influence can be seen in the return of clearer borders, more explicit controls, and stronger visual signifiers after excessively subtle interface trends.

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## 61. Variable-Font and Experimental Typography

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** Variable typography, kinetic type, expressive type, experimental web typography

Modern font technology allows one font file to interpolate between weights, widths, slants, and other characteristics.

### Typical elements

- Type changing in response to scrolling or cursor movement
- Smooth transitions between weights and widths
- Highly customized display lettering
- Responsive type proportions
- Animated headlines
- Text used as an interactive object
- Unconventional vertical or circular arrangements
- Typography replacing conventional illustration

This supports expressive designs without requiring many separate font files.

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## 62. Cursor-Driven Interaction

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** Custom cursor design, cursor interaction, magnetic cursor, pointer-led UI

The pointer itself becomes part of the visual experience.

### Typical elements

- Enlarged circular cursors
- Labels appearing inside the pointer
- Cursor changing over links or images
- Elements magnetically following the pointer
- Image previews attached to hover
- Trails, particles, or distortion effects
- Cursor-controlled 3D movement

Because custom cursors can obscure expected behavior, they are most common on experimental portfolios and campaign sites.

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## 63. No-Code and Template-Led Design

**Popular:** 2018–present

**Common names:** No-code design, visual-builder aesthetic, template-driven design, block-based web design

Visual site builders have democratized polished layouts and popularized repeatable patterns.

### Typical elements

- Modular page sections

- Large hero blocks
- Preset typography scales
- Repeated card systems
- Scroll animations
- Full-width section backgrounds
- Standardized testimonials, pricing, and FAQ modules
- Responsive behavior generated automatically
- Reliance on high-quality templates

No-code tools broadened access to sophisticated web production while also accelerating stylistic convergence.

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## 64. AI-Influenced Web Design

**Popular:** 2022–present

**Common names:** AI-assisted design, generative design, AI-generated web, adaptive AI interface

AI now affects both production workflows and visible website experiences.

### Typical elements

- Generatively created illustrations and imagery
- Rapidly produced layout variations
- Conversational search or assistant interfaces
- Personalized page content



- AI-generated summaries
- Interfaces organized around prompts
- Dynamic recommendations
- Synthetic video or background imagery
- Automated component and copy generation

This is not yet a single coherent visual style. It is better understood as a production and interaction trend that may appear inside minimal, maximalist, editorial, or application-oriented designs. Recent web-design histories describe the current era as increasingly shaped by AI-assisted and adaptive experiences.  Clique Studios +1

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## Useful Umbrella Categories

Many individual trends can be grouped into broader families:

| Family                  | Included styles                                               |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Early-Web Vernacular    | Raw HTML, personal homepages, banners, frames, pixel graphics |
| Immersive Multimedia    | Flash, parallax, video backgrounds, scrollytelling, 3D        |
| Realistic or Tactile UI | Aqua, skeuomorphism, neumorphism, claymorphism                |
| Reductionist UI         | Minimalism, flat design, Metro, Flat 2.0                      |
| Modular UI              | Portals, cards, design systems, bento grids, dashboards       |

| Family                     | Included styles                                                          |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Editorial Design           | Magazine grids, bold typography, broken grids, type-first layouts        |
| Retro-Futurism             | Cyber design, Y2K, webcore, pixel art                                    |
| Expressive Anti-Minimalism | Grunge, brutalism, neo-brutalism, maximalism                             |
| Atmospheric Surfaces       | Gradients, glassmorphism, duotone, organic shapes                        |
| Adaptive Architecture      | Fluid design, responsive design, mobile-first design                     |
| Interaction-Led Design     | Motion UI, custom cursors, scroll interaction, conversational interfaces |

A central pattern throughout this history is **reaction and counterreaction**: realism prompted flat design; excessive flatness led to Flat 2.0 and neumorphism; standardized minimalism encouraged brutalism and maximalism; and polished modern systems prompted renewed interest in the rough, personal early web. NN/G Nielsen Norman... +1

